beauty of our land—the emerald hills of Appalachia, the farms and small towns of the Midwest, the granite peaks of the Rockies, the rugged deserts of the Southwest, and, finally, the great metropolitan panorama of Southern California. It truly is “America, the Beautiful,” and God has, indeed, “shed His grace on thee.” I looked at the houses below and wondered about the people in those houses. Were they better off than they were eight years ago? I hoped so.

And yet as I reflected on what we had accomplished, I had a sense of incompleteness—that there was still work to be done. We need a constitutional amendment to require a balanced budget. Congressional redistricting has become a national disgrace and needs to be cleaned up. The president needs a line-item veto to cut out unnecessary spending.

I said earlier that in Hollywood if you didn’t sing or dance, you became an after-dinner speaker. I didn’t learn to sing or dance in Washington, so I was thinking about my plans to be back out there on the speaking circuit, trying to get the people to pressure their representatives to take action on these issues.

Just then there was a quiet knock on the door of our cabin and I was reminded that we were taking our last ride aboard what had been Air Force One. We were told there was a gathering of all of those on board—staff, press, and Secret Service—a chance to say good-bye before we landed. There were warm handshakes, tearful embraces, and lots of picture-taking. Finally, champagne was poured and glasses were raised. “Mission accomplished, Mr. President,” someone called out, “mission accomplished.”

Not yet, I thought to myself, not yet.